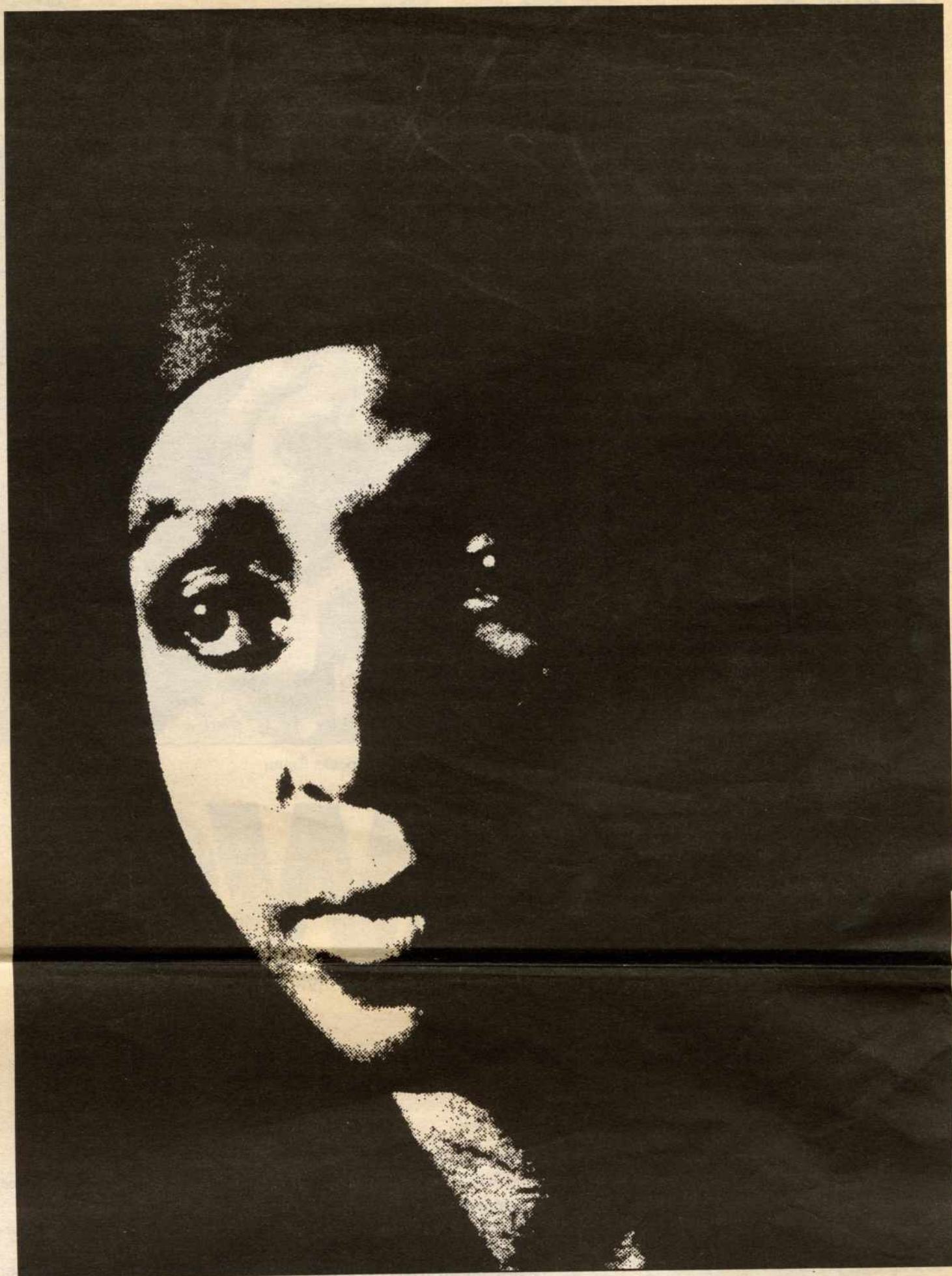


H A R A M B E E

*Harambee is
the Swahili
word meaning
"work together"*



Pan•Af•ri•can (pan-af-ri-kən) adj. pertaining to the cultural, political, and economic unification of the African peoples on the continent and in the diaspora

Close your eyes and imagine all of the things that the word home conjures up in your mind. Things like peace, security, love, acceptance, roots, and a knowing confidence come to mind. Unfortunately, for Africans living in America, these things are seldom analogous or representative of our 400 year displacement in this strange and hostile land.

Pan-Africanism Part II by Yolanda Madison

The African Woman Speaks

by Yolanda Madison

On March 7, 1992 at the UCLA Sunset Canyon Recreation Center, the African Women's Collective sponsored "The African Woman Speaks" Conference and Women's Music Festival. The conference was dedicated to all African women: To our ancestors who bore vicious attacks against their womanhood, to our mothers who have repeatedly sacrificed themselves for us to have a better way of life, and to the sistahs of today's generation, struggling to find a place in society where being white and male are the only attributes that validate your existence and guarantee your survival.

The conference included workshops on education and Pan-Africanism, culminating with a panel discussion titled "African Women: Defining our Role for the Future". The highlight of the conference was the Young Women's Survival Guide, which included a dynamic presentation by rap activist Sister Souljah, former member of the rap group Public Enemy.

The room was charged with anticipation and personal conviction as each member of the packed audience felt the impact of Souljah's brilliant analysis of the affects of white supremacy, sexism and other forms of internalized oppression on our communities. The fact that there were very few brotha's in the audience to receive the information was extremely disheartening. In the future the African Women's Collective plans to make a concerted effort to reach out to more brothas. To all of you brothas that could accurately identify the struggle of your sistahs as your very own, and showed up-PRAISE!

Sister Souljah specifically discussed the importance of African women developing healthy and positive self-images. This, she explained, would lead sistahs to using more sound judgement in their relationships with men and people in society as a whole. Never separating her message to African women and men from the perils we face in a racist society, Souljah constantly reinforced the fact that as a community, "WE ARE AT WAR"! Therefore we must strive for unity everyday.

The evening activities brought further beauty and positive affirmations to "The African Woman Speaks" program. The beauty of the night manifested itself in the Women's Music festival held at Wadsworth Theater following the conference. The concert featured such acts as a local hip-hop artist Quiet Storm, jazzological muse-oetress Phavia Kujichagulia, and performances by the African Student Union's African Dance Troupe, and the women of the African Women's Collective giving a dramatic rendition of Ntozake Shange's *For Colored Girls Who Have Considered Suicide When the Rainbow is Enuf*. It was an intense celebration of the creative, nurturing, and healing powers that African woman possess.



Scenes from the African Women Speaks forum

AWC

THE AFRICAN WOMEN'S COLLECTIVE

Sistahs are gonna work it out!

Organizational Goals

1. To create a bond and strengthen the relationship between African women on campus, in the community, in Africa and in the world.
2. To learn about and share with others African history and culture, particularly as it relates to the struggle of African women.
3. To provide an arena for African women to develop skills for leadership roles on campus and in the community.
4. To develop and encourage African women to become full participants in the struggle for African liberation and human rights.
5. To help develop and encourage African women to use their skills, talents, resources and knowledge to uplift humanity.
6. To discuss the history of racism, sexism and classism, and their effects on the historical development of African people.
7. To instill self-pride, self-confidence, self-respect, dignity and self-determination within African women.
8. To encourage African women to develop themselves spiritually mentally and physically.
9. To assist African women in achieving personal goals.
10. To work with African men in the development of stronger family and male/female relationships.
11. To promote African economic independence and self-reliance, by helping and encouraging African women to become financially self-sufficient.

Organizational Objectives

1. To hold meetings once a month enabling African women an opportunity to come together to share ideas and talents, and work on issues of concern.
2. To organize study sessions in which African history and culture are discussed through books, films, videos and speakers.
3. To train women to become participants and leaders in various community and campus organizations through public speaking preparations, workshops, etc. . .
4. To identify and highlight African women who are strong role models.
5. To organize forums and presentations that define and analyze racism, sexism and classism as they relate to the exploitation of African people,

particularly African women, with the goal of finding solutions.

6. To develop forums and presentations with African men to allow an exchange of communication, in order to strengthen the African family.

Four Points on African Women's Identity in Relationships with Men

1. We should put much effort into learning our role in world history and our any contributions to society. This includes knowing the contributions of our grandmothers, mothers, and other women in our families. The more we learn about ourselves the more love and respect we will have for ourselves and each other. It was Fannie Lou Hammer who said that we (African people) must first respect ourselves before we can expect others to respect us. We, women, must respect ourselves in order to be respected by men.

2. We are spiritual, intelligent, creative, caring courageous, resourceful, industrious, and among other things committed to our men and children! We should not expect less from our companions. Relationships are a very important aspect of our lives. Relationships can contribute to our productivity or devastate our growth and development. We are too important to society and to our liberation struggle, in general, to be preoccupied and held down by useless relationships. We cannot soar if we have extra baggage weighing down.

3. Do not become consumed in a relationship with a man to the point that you begin to ignore your personal interests and development. Our goals and aspirations are important - just look at all the outstanding contributions we have made to society! We must also spend quality time with our sistahs. Often when we hookup with a brotha, we no longer have the time or desire to hang with the homegirls. We must continue to be supportive and nurturing of one another at all times.

4. Finally, remember that love is giving and receiving. If we find ourselves always giving and rarely receiving (mentally, spiritually, and physically) then we are headed for self-destruction. If we give, give, give (like we often have a tendency to do) and receive nothing or very little in return, we will find ourselves with nothing else to give anyone, especially to ourselves.

Sistahs, we are the mothers of civilization. We are the primary educators of our nation. Our state of mind is crucial to the development of the African nation and the world. Therefore, we must remain serious about our liberation which is ultimately our responsibility. Many of us are at the point where we understand that we are victims of male supremacy, as well as racism and classism. What then must we do? The most important step we should take is to continue educating ourselves so that we do not feed into our own exploitation and oppression. The goal is not to hate men or to focus on making them change, but to love and change ourselves thus forcing a change on our men. When we change, our brothas will change and then we will be able to build a liberation movement together, which includes the liberation of women.

Peace and Love